‘Hello,’ I said.

‘Oh-oh,’ he said. He looked surprised.

‘We’ll come down and see you later,’ I said. ‘We just want to clarify a few things that Alan Rusbridger showed us.’

I’ve never in my life seen anyone’s face collapse like that. He went white. As we walked away, our group said the news reporter looked like a person who had just been caught with a murder weapon.

We went upstairs to see Alan Rusbridger. *Der Spiegel*’s editor came in. I was shouting, almost certainly, and I asked him point-blank if they had given the material to the *New York Times*. Rusbridger just dodged the question. ‘The first thing we need to do,’ I said, ‘is establish who’s got a copy of the material. Who does not have a copy of the material, and who does? Because we’re not ready to publish.’ His eyes rolled around the room. He didn’t know where to look. ‘Did you give a copy of the cables to the *New York Times*?’

All this business with the *Independent* journalist had given them a bit of script to warble on, but it didn’t hold, and I just kept pressing them. ‘We need to understand what sort of people we’re dealing with,’ I said. ‘Are we dealing with people whose word we can trust or are we not? Because if we’re not dealing with people whose written word we can trust, then . . .’ It now looked like all their eyes were rolling round the room. It was like a cartoon, all these grown men finding themselves unable to face the truth of what they had done, or to put forward some argument to try to defend themselves. I would later be characterised as some sort of nutcase for shouting at them. But who wouldn’t shout, when the stakes were so high? Who wouldn’t lose their temper with such lily-livered gits hiding in their glass offices? It was soon clear to everyone that Alan’s refusal to answer the question was as good as an admission. It was only for legal reasons that he wasn’t saying ‘yes’ or ‘no’. My respect for the man plummeted to nothing. I mean, here’s this guy, the editor of an important newspaper, an institution, indeed, a man older than me and with a crucial issue in front of him, and what we get is eyes rolling around the room like marbles on a pogo stick. It was just the most incredible thing and I couldn’t believe I was witnessing it.

I’m sure I must have given them some lengthy harangue about honour and so on. You do, in those circumstances. Anyway, we ended up being there debating it for seven hours, then we went downstairs to come up with a plan. The Guardian had known all along what it wanted to do – it wanted